

Government Medical College (RPGMC) a month ago, and then went on to add, "My death will bring about a change". He died of brain haemorrhage after being mercilessly beaten up along with 12 batchmates on the night of March 6 and 7 by four drunk seniors—Ajay Kumar Verma, Naveen Verma, Abhinav Verma and Mukul Sharma—who are now in jail. The incident took place in the common room which is just 50 m from the principal's office.

An upper middle-class Kashmiri boy with a natural

seniors. Last year, the Raghavan Committee set up to suggest remedies for the issue, felt that educational institutes are lenient on ragging issues.

Amann had described the consistent and brutal ragging in his complaint to college authorities written shortly before he died. "I was slapped seven times.... Received a traumatic perforation on my left ear." He had consulted the in-house ENT specialist, Dr Hardeep Singh, who did tell the police about the perforation but did not investigate its cause. The then princi-

ging in all its aspects, including its impact on the victims. Also, Amann was a Kashmiri in a Himachali-dominated college. He was tall, good-looking, intelligent and fluent in English, which may have led to jealousy. His not being fluent in Hindi, earned him ridicule. "Every time he pronounced a Hindi word incorrectly, he would get a slap," says a batchmate. He had realised that tolerating ragging is akin to encouraging it and had recently asked a senior, "What if I slap back a senior when he slaps me next? Will



AMANN'S PARENTS PRIYA AND RAJENDRA (EXTREME LEFT) LEADING A PROTEST

talent for writing, Amann took up medicine because he wanted to serve humanity. He joined RPGMC last year, a government medical college bound by anti-ragging norms laid down by the Supreme Court. The apex court has now issued show cause notices to the Government and the college for ignoring its anti-ragging guidelines. The larger tragedy is that this is not an isolated case. A girl student of an agricultural and engineering college in Andhra Pradesh attempted suicide after she was allegedly forced to dance nude by her

pal Dr Suresh Sankhyan asked the students to file a complaint only after the father of one of the 13 students complained to a minister. Amann did complain but collapsed 15 minutes later and was rushed to the hospital where attempts to revive him failed.

Considering that of the 13 assaulted boys only Amann suffered fatal injuries, it can be said that he was specifically targeted, especially since he frequently questioned ragging as a practice. In a telling diagram he drew a few days before his death, he had analysed rag-

Gross Neglect

- The Supreme Court in May 2007 had suggested making ragging a punishable offence by adding a section to the IPC.
- Calling it a violation of human rights, the court wanted to include abetment to ragging, criminal conspiracy to rag, causing injury, use of force and sexual offences to be included in the section. It also wanted the burden of proof to lie on the accused.
- The Home Ministry is yet to react to these suggestions and formulate a law. It remains a state subject.

they kill me for this?" They did, but it may be a death that will not go in vain. Amann's family have now devoted themselves to this cause full-time in the name of "Amann Movement" that demands speedy justice for him and seeks to ensure that he is the last victim of ragging. "He has left a war for us to fight; it is become a part of our karma. When you start believing in something too strongly it becomes ultimate truth. The pain is relieved and it starts to drive you," says Rajendra Kachroo. It's a war worth fighting and an attitude worth emulating. ■